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Abstract

AI-based digital legacy systems, which use artificial intelligence to recreate a deceased person's identity, are moving from niche technology toward a real, if commercially volatile, product category. This dissertation investigates the extent to which perceived ability, benevolence, privacy, and ethical governance predict trust in these systems, and willingness to use them.

A cross-sectional study involving 129 individuals who use technology collected data that was used to test the predictive value of a trust model based on four predictors. Collectively, these factors explained more than half of the variation in people's trust. Benevolence, which measures how caring and emotionally appropriate the system was perceived to be, was the strongest predictor, followed by Ability, which measures whether the system seemed genuinely competent. Privacy and Governance were not significant predictors, despite recording the highest agreement scores of any factor in the study: participants stated concerns about data protection and regulation did not translate into a measurable effect on their trust.

These findings suggest trust in this domain is shaped more by perceived competence and care than by the safeguards commonly assumed central to user concern, which is a gap that carries a practical risk: systems designed to appear caring and capable could earn high trust while remaining under-governed. The study contributes an early empirical test of trust formation in this novel application of AI and recommends future research using larger samples and comparisons between anticipated and lived trust among bereaved populations.

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1. Introduction

In 2021, actor William Shatner worked with the AI company StoryFile to record interview footage, creating an interactive version of himself that let family, fans, and future generations hold real-time conversations with him, "so my children's children can get to know me," in his words. The same technology was later used for people who had already died: museum visitors could talk with recreations of Holocaust survivors and WWII veterans (AV Magazine, 2025). Three years after the Shatner project, StoryFile ran out of money and filed for bankruptcy (Wodecki, 2024). This left the people who had trusted the company with their memories, and their families' access to them, with no clear answer about what would happen next. AI systems that recreate a person's identity are already real, already growing, and already capable of failing, which is exactly why the question of whether, and why, people trust them matters.

To what extent do people's perceptions regarding a system's ability, benevolence, privacy, and ethical governance predict how much they trust it, and whether they would use it? A single question like "do you trust this system?" cannot tell us whether someone trusts it because it seems competent, because it seems caring, because their data feels safe, or because they believe it is well-regulated, and each of those reasons points to a different lesson for how these systems should be built and governed. This is why the study evaluates trust as four different predictors instead of the general notion of trust, based on past literature about trust in technology (Mayer, Davis & Schoorman, 1995; Davis, 1989; Venkatesh et al., 2003), though never before tested on a technology this personal and this emotionally sensitive.

Based on the literature reviewed, no existing study has closed this gap: no research has tested a validated, multi-dimensional trust model against a general, non-bereaved public's reactions to this specific technology.

Testing whether ability, benevolence, privacy, and governance each predict trust matters for a practical reason: as these systems become more common, and as new regulation such as the EU AI Act starts shaping how they must operate (Billah et al., 2025), understanding what actually earns the public's trust has direct, practical relevance for how it should be designed, governed, and communicated.

2. Literature Review

The validated, multi-dimensional trust instruments this study draws on have mostly been built and tested on functional and safety-critical applications, such as autonomous vehicles or medical diagnostic tools, where trust failures produce physical or operational harm. Digital legacy AI falls outside this frame entirely: a malfunction here, getting someone's recreated identity wrong, or handling their memory carelessly, produces psychological and reputational harm rather than physical harm.

2.1. Trust in AI: Theoretical Foundations

Mayer, Davis and Schoorman's (1995) defines trust as acceptance of vulnerability owing to one's positive expectations of someone else's intentions. At its simplest, trust depends on whether someone is perceived as capable of fulfilling what they claim they can do. However, competence alone does not fully explain trust. People are also more likely to trust someone when they believe that person genuinely cares about their interests and behaves according to consistent and acceptable principles. This distinction matters because it lets this study ask a more precise question than simply do people trust this system, one that separates why that trust exists rather than just measuring whether it does. Building on this model, privacy is included as fourth factor that is particularly relevant to AI-based digital legacy systems. It therefore tests ability, benevolence, privacy, and governance as separate predictors of trust, rather than treating trust as a single overall judgement. Davis's (1989) Technology Acceptance Model(TAM) provides a complementary perspective by explaining technology adoption through perceived usefulness and ease of use. However, TAM focuses primarily on whether people are likely to adopt a technology, whereas this study is specifically concerned with why they trust it.

Measuring trust requires an appropriate tool rather than just the theory itself. In practice, trust in artificial intelligence is measured using Jian, Bisantz and Drury's (2000) Trust in Automation Scale, and subsequently refined by McGrath et al. (2025) into a shorter version. They confirmed that it captures a stable pattern of trust/distrust across everyday AI applications, such as autonomous vehicles and recommendation engines. A newer tool to measure trust, Wang et al.'s (2026) Human-Generative AI Trust Scale, was developed and validated among Chinese university students utilizing generative AI for education support. It measures trust through benevolence, competence, and reciprocity, but notably removed its original fourth factor, perceived risk, after finding that it behaved inconsistently with the rest of the scale. The authors attribute this to the particular cultural and regulatory context of their sample. However, this also raises possibility that risk and privacy may act as an entirely separate component of

trust more broadly and thus requiring to be measured separately from a general measure of trust. This is the design choice followed by this four-factor model. A related pattern is documented more broadly in AI trust research: Kreps et al. (2023) describe a "trust paradox," where people can hold real concerns about a technology while those concerns operate largely independently of their overall willingness to trust or use it. Neither instrument, however, was developed or tested in a context this emotionally sensitive: a technology that simulates the identity of a specific person after death.

2.2. AI-Based Digital Legacy Systems: Context and Ethical Terrain

General trust research explicates how people evaluate a technology's competence and reliability, but digital legacy AI introduces concerns that extend beyond this conventional framework, particularly issues of consent, dignity, and grief that standard trust scales were not designed to capture. A distinct literature has emerged specifically around AI recreations of deceased people, sometimes referred to as griefbots, deadbots, or digital afterlife services. One of the first frameworks for governance in this industry was offered by Öhman and Floridi (2018). The authors make a direct comparison to how archaeology treats human remains: just as a society's handling of physical remains reflects its values around dignity, they argue digital remains deserve the same protection. A related paper (Öhman & Floridi, 2017) raises concerns about commercial control over this kind of data, a concern this study's governance measure speaks to directly. Lindemann (2022) narrows this down further, starting with consent: can the deceased ever meaningfully agree to being recreated, given they cannot approve of how the recreation is actually used after the fact? Even where there is consent, prolonged interaction with the recreation may carry its own psychological cost for the bereaved. And underlying both problems is a legal one: most jurisdictions offer no protection at all for a deceased person's data, leaving these questions with no formal framework to resolve them within.

This dignity-based argument has older roots: Pearson (1999) argues that how a society treats human remains reflects and reinforces its values around memory and personhood, the same principle Öhman and Floridi apply to digital remains. Stokes (2015) extends this argument by suggesting that deleting someone's digital remains can amount to a kind of "second death": a loss of moral status that is distinct from their biological death. These governance concerns also continue beyond the point of death. Cunneen et al. (2026) argue that digital human twins raise ongoing questions about who controls them over time and under what conditions they should eventually be shut down. There are some empirical studies that have approached these concepts directly: Xygkou et al. (2023) studied how bereaved people actually used

chatbot technology while grieving, finding it could offer real comfort but also risked complicating the grieving process, while Wallace et al. (2020) found similar patterns in how physical and digital keepsakes shape ongoing experience of bereavement. Even so, this remains an exception. Most of the literature is based on ethical reasoning rather than evidence of how people actually respond. Neither Xyngkou et al. (2023) nor Wallace et al. (2020) examined trust itself as a measurable, multidimensional construct. This creates an important empirical gap, since ethical arguments alone cannot show whether the public actually shares these issues, or how strongly they hold them. A further complication applies to any attempt to close this gap through hypothetical research: Loewenstein (2005) argues that people are systematically poor at predicting how they will think or feel in an emotionally intense state while reasoning from a neutral one, a "hot-cold empathy gap" with direct relevance to anyone imagining how they would respond to a technology like this before actually needing it.

2.3. Emotional Engagement and Benevolence in AI Trust

The literature above establishes why benevolence matters in this context, while proof of how it functions in practice comes from adjacent, though less emotionally sensitive, service settings. Chi and Hoang Vu (2023) surveyed 507 banking and telecommunications customers in Vietnam and found that only empathy response, not anthropomorphism, the attribution of human-like qualities to a non-human agent (Epley, Waytz & Cacioppo, 2007), or making it responsive, had a direct effect on trust in AI. Anthropomorphism and responsiveness did not directly influence trust; instead, they mattered indirectly by improving how effectively the system appeared to communicate. This implies that merely enhancing a system's appearance to be more human does not suffice for engendering trust. The crucial aspect lies in whether the human-likeness enables an interaction that is deemed appropriate and effective by the user. This differentiation is particularly relevant to the measure of benevolence, which focuses on care and appropriate emotional handling rather than surface-level human resemblance. An important limitation in this case is the fact that the banking and telecommunications industries do not involve high stakes in comparison with digital legacy systems. Whether empathy works the same way when the subject is death and memory remains untested.

2.4. Privacy and Governance in AI Trust

Even a system that seems caring can still be distrusted if its data policies could raise concern as being unsafe, which is why privacy is seen as an independent trust predictor apart from benevolence. Legal literature consistently argues that privacy law never designed with the deceased in mind, a gap that Harbinja (2017) traces directly to the lack of any legal concept

of a deceased data subject. Kohl (2022) makes a similar point but from another angle, medical confidentiality. It shows that the same blind spot recurs across multiple areas of law, not just one. Nwabueze and White (2024) go further still, arguing that the law needs to be reappraised entirely rather than patched piecemeal. Pearce (2022) focuses on one implication of this gap: whether consent given before death can meaningfully govern data use afterward. However, Szwajdler goes even further, expanding the discussion beyond privacy to digital inheritance more broadly, and drawing an analogy with how the law deals with physical assets. The public attitude shows the same unresolved gap: Nakagawa and Orita (2024) found general reluctance in Japan to allow the continued use of a deceased person's data, with no clear link to religious belief, suggesting that the privacy concern is not simply cultural. Governance research offers a broader vocabulary for the same problem: Floridi et al. (2018) propose transparency and accountability as guiding AI principles generally, while Billah et al. (2025) apply this more specifically by assessing how large language models measure up against the EU AI Act's actual requirements, making their work one of the few sources connecting trust and formal regulation this directly.

2.5. Empirical Evidence on Acceptance of Digital Legacy AI

The closest empirical comparison comes from Lu (2024), who surveyed 319 people on what makes them resist AI-based "resurrection" technology, a study of what stops adoption, not what builds trust in it, and used no validated trust instrument despite a reasonable sample size. Fu et al. (2025) came closer still, using a validated framework, an extended UTAUT model, and reporting it rigorously, but only among people whose family member had recently died of cancer.

2.6. Synthesis and Research Gap

The digital-afterlife literature identifies what should concern individuals, consent, dignity, privacy, but largely argues from principle rather than empirical evidence. Authors such as Lindemann, Hollanek, and Nowaczyk-Basińska outline our concerns without determining whether people hold these concerns in reality. The studies that have gotten close to testing this empirically, Lu (2024) and Fu et al. (2025), still fall short in different ways. Lu measures resistance rather than trust, while Fu et al. measure trust in a population that is too specific for the findings to be readily generalized.

Closing that gap requires a test of a four-factor trust model (ability, benevolence, privacy, governance) against a general non-bereaved public, a combination that has not previously been examined together. This matters because, as digital legacy services move towards wider availability, understanding what people need to trust such a system before they ever encounter one can inform how these technologies should be designed, regulated, and communicated.

Ability and benevolence are hypothesized to positively predict trust, while privacy concerns are expected to be associated with trust and ethical governance is also hypothesized to positively predict it.

3. Methodology

3.1. Research Design

This study used a quantitative survey to test four hypotheses: H1, ability positively predicts trust; H2, benevolence positively predicts trust; H3, privacy concerns are associated with trust; and H4, ethical governance positively predicts trust.

3.2. Data Collection Method

Data was collected using an online questionnaire on Qualtrics (see the full instrument and ethics approval in Appendix A and B respectively). The questionnaire included a hypothetical scenario describing an AI-based digital legacy system and 17 questions on a 5-point Likert scales corresponding to the study's predictors, ability, benevolence, privacy, and governance, and its outcome measure, overall trust and willingness to engage. For instance, the ability section asked people to rate agreement with statements such as "This system would accurately represent how the person actually communicated." Items were written specifically for this study, since no published scale identified in the literature reviewed measures trust in digital legacy AI directly. Item wording drew on Mayer et al.'s (1995) competence and care-based dimensions for the ability and benevolence sections, and on the Trust in Automation Scale (Jian et al., 2000; McGrath et al., 2025) for the trust and willingness-to-engage section. Privacy was measured separately, since Wang et al. (2026) found it behaved differently enough from their scale's other factors to warrant its own measure.

Participants were recruited through non-probability convenience and snowball sampling, distributed via personal and professional networks, university channels and groups, and LinkedIn. Eligibility was restricted to adults aged 18 and above. A sample of 150-200 was targeted, with a minimum of 100 completed responses required.

Only responses that were fully completed, confirmed the participant to be 18 or older, and included informed consent were retained for analysis. Time taken to complete the survey was not considered an exclusion criterion. This is consistent with comparable published studies in this research area (Chi & Hoang Vu, 2023; Fu et al., 2025), neither of which excluded responses on this basis.

3.3. Data Analysis Methods

Before testing the hypotheses, it was necessary to ensure reliability of the instrument. Reliability of the measure was ensured using Cronbach's alpha, with a threshold of 0.70

(Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994). McDonald's omega was employed as an alternative where required. These tests confirmed that each set of items measured one coherent construct. Correlations between the predictor composites were also examined, since predictors that overlap too heavily can prevent a regression from distinguishing their separate effects. Once this was established, multiple linear regression, run in Jamovi, tested the hypotheses directly by regressing overall trust on the predictor composites, with AI familiarity entered as a covariate to account for its own separate influence on trust. An exploratory correlation between age and overall trust was conducted separately.

3.4. Methodological Limitations

Convenience and snowball sampling limits how far these findings generalize beyond people reachable through the researcher's personal networks. However, it was partially remedied through reaching out to potential participants using various independent channels, personal networks, university contacts and LinkedIn, across different countries rather than one source alone. Even so, the sample remains self-selected, meaning that the associations identified here are likely to apply most strongly to similarly digitally active populations and should be generalized to the wider public cautiously. The sample also became global via LinkedIn rather than remaining focused on the UK as originally intended, see further discussion in Chapter 5. Self-report data also carries a risk of social desirability bias, particularly for a sensitive topic. Participants answered anonymously and were not asked to justify their choices, which reduced pressure to provide socially acceptable answers and encouraged more honest responses. Finally, because participants evaluated the scenario hypothetically rather than from the perspective of actual bereavement, their responses may have been influenced by the hot-cold empathy gap (Loewenstein, 2005), whereby individuals in an emotionally neutral state may inaccurately anticipate how they would think, feel, or respond in a future emotionally intense situation. This means that the trust reported here should be interpreted as anticipated trust, rather than as a reliable indication of how individuals would respond while grieving. At the same time, the cross-sectional design helps detect associations, but not casual relationships. Because the survey was anonymous, duplicate responses could not be identified using IP addresses, so response-pattern screening was used instead. Although this study's items showed acceptable reliability, they have not been independently validated in the way an established scale has, which remains an important limitation given that every result in this study depends on these items functioning correctly.

4. Results

4.1. Data Cleaning

A total of 183 responses were collected. Responses were included only if the participant completed the survey in full, confirmed they were 18 years of age or older, and gave informed consent, criteria met by 129 of the 183 responses, a retention rate of 70.5%. Five additional responses, generated while building and testing the survey itself, were excluded separately, as they were the researcher's own submissions rather than genuine participants. This exceeds the minimum of 100 completed responses required for the analysis.

4.2. Sample Characteristics

Understanding who responded matters for judging how far these findings can reasonably generalize. Participants age was from 18 to 79 years (Mean=31.5, Standard Deviation=12.2, Median=26). Three participants entered their age with additional text (e.g., "61 years") rather than a number alone, and the numeric value was extracted from each. 47% of respondents were females (n=60), while 43% were males (n=56). 6 people preferred not to say and 5 self-describing. Participants were drawn evenly from the United Kingdom (n=61) and India (n=60), while some other countries contributed with small number of participants. 68% reported being "very" or "extremely" familiar with AI tools.

4.3. Reliability of Measures

Reliability was assessed before hypothesis testing, since a predictor based on unreliable items cannot test its hypothesis accurately, regardless of the regression results. Alpha for each of the constructs is shown in Table 4.1. Ability, Benevolence, Privacy, and Trust all exceeded the conventional 0.70 threshold. Governance did not, with the original four-item scale returning $\alpha = 0.56$. Governance was originally measured using four items, but one item, which combined regulation and independent oversight in a single statement, did not correlate well with the others. Removing this item improved reliability to $\alpha = 0.60$, although this remained below the 0.70 threshold. McDonald's omega, a related check less affected by that kind of item inconsistency, confirmed the same shortfall ($\omega=0.64$). Therefore, the Governance result for H4 should be interpreted with greater caution than the results for the other three predictors.

Construct	Items	Cronbach's α	McDonald's ω
Ability	3	0.82	-
Benevolence	3	0.79	-
Privacy	3	0.72	-
Governance	3	0.60	0.639
Trust (outcome)	4	0.87	-

Table 4.1: Scale Reliability

4.4. Descriptive Statistics

Before testing the hypotheses, it is worthwhile considering the general response pattern for each construct separately, as it helps us understand what people generally believed before the regression identifies which of those beliefs predicted trust. Descriptive statistics for each construct are shown in Table 4.2. Privacy and Governance constructs received the highest mean scores, indicating that people agreed strongly that data protection and regulatory oversight are important. Benevolence received the lowest mean and even fell below the midpoint of the scale, indicating skepticism that such a system would handle memory with genuine care.

Construct	M	SD	Min	Max
Ability	3.30	1.06	1.00	5.00
Benevolence	2.74	1.10	1.00	5.00
Privacy	4.44	0.70	2.00	5.00
Governance	4.41	0.70	2.00	5.00
Trust	3.30	1.16	1.00	5.00

Table 4.2: Descriptive Statistics

4.5. Correlations Between Constructs

Correlations between the four predictors were examined before the regression, since predictors that overlap too strongly can make it harder to distinguish their individual effects. Correlations among the predictors using Pearson's correlation coefficients are presented in Table 4.3, where r shows how strongly two things are related (from -1 to $+1$, with 0 meaning no relationship), and p shows how likely that relationship is to be real rather than chance, with values below 0.05 generally treated as reliable. Ability and Benevolence were found to be

correlated to each other and with Trust. Privacy and Governance were also significantly correlated with each other, but neither showed a significant correlation with Trust.

	Ability	Benevolence	Privacy	Governance	Trust
Ability	-				
Benevolence	0.592***	-			
Privacy	-0.035	-0.077	-		
Governance	-0.005	-0.106	0.601***	-	
Trust	0.566***	0.724***	0.007	-0.084	-

Note: values range from -1 to +1, with values closer to 0 indicating no relationship. *** $p < .001$.

Table 4.3: Correlation Matrix

4.6. Regression Analysis and Hypothesis Testing

The regression brings all predictors together to test whether each one still predicts Trust after accounting for the others, rather than examining each predictor separately as in the earlier correlations. A multiple linear regression analysis was performed with Trust as the dependent variable and Ability, Benevolence, Privacy, and Governance as predictors, and AI familiarity as a covariate (N=121). A multiple linear regression tested Trust as the outcome, with Ability, Benevolence, Privacy, and Governance as predictors and AI familiarity as a covariate. This specific test used 121 of the 129 clean responses. The remaining 8 had completed and submitted the survey, but had skipped one or more individual questions needed to calculate all five scores, an option every participant was given. The model as a whole was statistically significant, indicating that the result was unlikely to have occurred by chance, $F(5,115) = 29.2$, $p < 0.001$. The model explained roughly 56% of the differences in how much people trusted the system ($R^2=0.559$), a strong result showing these four factors, together, are a meaningful explanation for people's trust, not just a weak or partial one. Age showed no meaningful association with Trust. Neither the correlation across the full age range nor the direct comparison between younger and older respondents found a statistically significant difference in Trust ($r = .057$, $p = .554$, $N = 112$; $t(110) = 0.151$, $p = .880$). Variance Inflation Factor (VIF), which checks whether predictors overlap too much to trust their individual results, ranged from 1.04 to 1.55, well below the level that would indicate a problem.

Ability and Benevolence both significantly predicted Trust, supporting H1 and H2, with Benevolence the stronger of the two. Privacy and Governance did not, meaning H3 and H4 were not supported.

Predictor	B (estimate)	SE	Standard Estimate (β)	t	p
(Constant)	0.397	0.629	-	0.630	0.530
Ability	0.229	0.083	0.212	2.768	0.007
Benevolence	0.626	0.081	0.595	7.714	<0.001
Privacy	0.197	0.133	0.112	1.482	0.141
Governance	-0.175	0.130	-0.102	-1.344	0.182
AI familiarity	0.082	0.074	0.074	1.167	0.246

Table 4.4: Regression Coefficients

4.7. Secondary Analysis: Age

Age showed no meaningful association with Trust. Neither the correlation across the full age range nor the direct comparison between younger and older respondents found a statistically significant difference in Trust ($r = 0.056$, $p = 0.556$, $N = 114$; $t(110) = 0.131$, $p = 0.896$).

Group	N	Mean Trust
Younger (≤ 26 years)	58	3.40
Older (>26 years)	56	3.37

Table 4.5: Trust by Age Group

5. Discussion

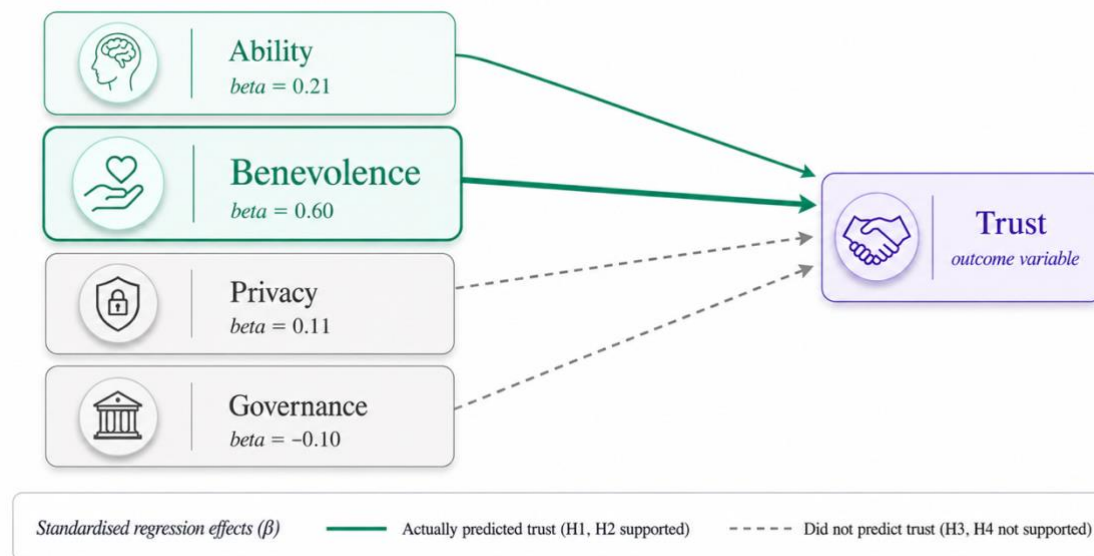


Figure 5.1: Path diagram showing which predictors significantly predicted trust

5.1. Predictors of Trust: Ability and Benevolence

People's trust in these systems came down to one thing more than anything else: whether they believed the AI would handle someone's memory with genuine care. Whether the system seemed capable and technically competent also mattered, but far less. This echoes Chi and Hoang Vu (2023) findings in the very different context of banking and telecommunications: people did not trust a system simply because it appeared intelligent or human-like, but because it seemed to genuinely care about getting things right for them. Applied here, that means respondents weren't really asking "Can this AI be convincing in bringing a person back?" Rather, it was "Would it take its responsibility seriously?" And answer to the second question mattered more heavily than the first one.

In fact, this poses an interesting challenge to a commonly assumption about how we perceive trust in AI. In typical scenarios where automation is involved, like a chatbot handling a refund request, people mostly care whether the machine gets the job done effectively. The moment a task touches memory, identity, and grief, trust seems to work by a different set of rules entirely, and instruments built to measure trust in ordinary AI may simply be measuring the wrong thing when applied to something so personal.

5.2. Privacy and Governance: Concern Without Predictive Power

Here's a genuinely interesting finding. When directly asked, the respondents made it abundantly clear that data protection and good regulation were extremely important to them, far more important than any other issue raised in the survey. However, when it came to predicting their level of trust in the system, none of that showed up (Privacy: $p=0.141$; Governance: $p=0.182$). Although both numbers are above the 0.05 level that researchers use to determine whether a finding is real, we can't say for certain whether either affects trust, as opposed to seeming to influence it randomly within the sample of survey participants. People who placed greater importance on privacy were no more or less trusting of the system than those who placed less importance on it.

This is not so much a contradiction in the data as a real, well-documented trend in how people operate. People can have strong views about something without those views strongly affecting their actual behavior or decisions, a pattern known as the "trust paradox" (Kreps et al., 2023) and discussed in Chapter 2. One plausible explanation of this phenomenon based on the legal literature reviewed earlier is that privacy and adequate oversight are basic expectations rather than things they actively consider when deciding whether to trust a system. It is similar to a car's brakes. People assume they work and only pay attention when something goes wrong. The governance finding carries an important caveat: the survey items used to measure it were less reliable than the rest of the questionnaire. Its lack of association with trust should therefore be treated as a genuine possibility rather than a definitive conclusion.

5.3. Comparison with Prior Empirical Research

Other researchers examining similar questions have found a different result. Fu et al. (2025) studied families of cancer patients who were actually facing loss and found that ethical and privacy concerns did influence whether they would use a similar technology, with a considerably stronger and statistically significant effect ($\beta = -0.227$) than the much weaker, non-significant effects found here for Privacy and Governance ($\beta = 0.112$ and $\beta = -0.102$). The likely explanation is not that one study is wrong, but that the two groups were in very different emotional situations. To someone experiencing actual loss, ethical and governance issues might be much more pressing, whereas to someone evaluating the technology hypothetically, those same concerns may simply feel less immediately. Lu (2024) did not test a comparable multidimensional trust model, so a direct predictor-level comparison is not possible. Lu (2024) approached the issue from another angle, finding that unfamiliarity and discomfort drive resistance to this technology aligns naturally with this study's own finding that competence mattered, but less than genuine care. This complements with the present study's

finding that competence does matter, but less than whether the system is perceived as acting with genuine care.

5.4. Secondary Findings

Age made no meaningful difference to how much respondents trusted the technology, with younger and older participants reporting similar levels of trust. This runs against the common assumption that younger, more technologically comfortable individuals would be more trusting. A related item measured directly in the survey also showed strong agreement that this type of technology should be restricted to licensed professionals, such as therapists. This level of agreement was similar to that seen for Privacy and Governance, reinforcing the same pattern: respondents held strong views about how the technology should be controlled, but those views did not appear to be what was actually driving trust.

5.5. Anticipated Versus Lived Trust

The participants here all imagined how they would react to this technology, rather than experiencing the emotion of grief when using the technology, the hot-cold empathy gap already examined in Chapter 3. This is actually an intrinsic part of the design, and one that is certainly worth pointing out since it can be used as a basis for future research that can examine the discrepancy between anticipated reactions and actual reactions once individuals start using the technology under a condition of real grief. What the current study gives us is the first half of this equation, a clear, well-evidenced account of anticipated trust, exactly the kind of understanding that shapes how a technology gets designed and regulated before most people ever encounter it.

5.6. Theoretical and Practical Contributions

There is an interesting insight coming from these findings: in emotionally loaded situations like this one, people seem to trust based more on perceived character, "does this feel caring?", than on perceived competence, "can it do the job well?", thus contradicting the common pattern of trust in AI when it comes to common day-to-day applications. This also points to a possibility worth naming: a system designed to seem warm and caring, but poorly regulated behind the scenes, could still gain people's trust, because governance is not the factor people are actually for. Researchers already highlighted the concern of comforting grief AI designed around grief could prolong someone's pain rather than help them move through it (Lindemann,

2022; Hollanek & Nowaczyk-Basińska, 2024) that possibility might go completely unnoticed by exactly the kind of trust measurement a company might use to decide the technology is working well. The risk also does not end once a system is launched. Who controls someone's digital memory, and what happens to it years later, remains an ongoing responsibility rather than a one-time decision made at the point of creation (Cunneen et al., 2026).

6. Conclusion

To what extent do perceived ability, benevolence, privacy, and ethical governance predict trust in AI-based digital legacy systems and willingness to use them? This is a straightforward question with an uneven answer. Ability and Benevolence were significant predictors of trust, supporting H1 and H2, whereas Privacy and Governance were not significant and, thus, hypotheses H3 and H4 were not supported, despite being the most strongly endorsed concerns in the sample. Together, these predictors and AI familiarity as a covariate explained 55.9% of the variance in trust, representing a substantial proportion in a novel measurement context.

User's perceptions of trustworthiness were shaped primarily by perceived competence and, even more strongly, by perceived care (Objectives 1-2). Privacy concerns, although strongly held, did not translate into a measurable effect on trust (Objective 3). Ethical governance showed the same trend, although this finding should be treated with greater caution because the governance scale showed below-threshold reliability (Objective 4). Willingness to engage with and support such systems was measured as part of the overall trust construct rather than as a separate outcome; the factors shaping this combined measure were therefore narrower than originally hypothesized (Objective 5).

The principal contribution here lies in the fact that it is empirical, rather than theoretical. It is one of the first tests of the multidimensional model of trust derived from Mayer et al. (1995) within the emotionally loaded context of identity simulating AI, applied to the non-bereaved sample of people, a combination not previously examined together. The findings suggest that trust in this context may depend more on perceived competence and care than on the privacy and regulatory safeguards often assumed to be central concerns. It is in line with the AI trust paradox outlined by Kreps et al. (2023). This divergence between strongly stated concerns and their limited measurable influence on trust is consistent with the AI trust paradox described by Kreps et al. (2023).

Several limitations affect how these findings should be interpreted. The usage of non-probability convenience and snowball sampling methods reduces the generalizability of results. In addition, below the threshold reliability of the Governance scale means that H4 cannot be interpreted with the same confidence as H1 and H2. Most importantly, all findings reflect anticipated rather than lived trust, as they were based on a non-bereaved sample responding hypothetically to a technology whose full emotional significance may only become apparent in the context of actual grief.

This points to a clear direction for future research. Directly comparing anticipated trust with lived trust, possibly in a longitudinal study using bereaved individuals, would provide valuable

information on whether the hot-cold empathy gap identified here has a real effect on trust in the situation when the person experiences grief. A larger, probability-based replication would also strengthen confidence in the governance findings, ideally using a revised and independently piloted scale. Finally, since trust in this study appeared largely disconnected from governance concerns, future research should examine how governance and regulation can be made more visible to users rather than remaining an assumed background condition. This would have direct value for the responsible design of these systems as they move towards wider availability.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Full Survey Instrument



Trust and Willingness to Engage with AI-Based Digital Legacy Systems

AI-based digital legacy systems use artificial intelligence to preserve or recreate aspects of a person's digital presence after death. They may be built using messages, emails, photos, videos, voice recordings, and other digital content to create an interactive digital representation of that person. Some questions in this survey discuss death, memory, digital legacy, and AI recreations after death. While you will not be asked about your personal experiences of bereavement or loss, you may find these topics emotionally sensitive.

Participation is voluntary. You may skip any question or stop the survey at any time before submitting your responses. If you have any questions, please contact Sakshi Sakle at sakshi-yugesh.sakle@warwick.ac.uk. Please note that once you have submitted the survey, your responses will be anonymised and cannot be withdrawn, as it will no longer be possible to identify your individual responses. For more information, please refer to [Wbs participant information leaflet 2025-26](#)

While you will not be asked about your personal experiences of bereavement or loss, you may find these topics emotionally sensitive.

Participation is voluntary. You may skip any question or stop the survey at any time before submitting your responses. If you have any questions, please contact Sakshi Sakle at sakshi-yugesh.sakle@warwick.ac.uk. Please note that once you have submitted the survey, your responses will be anonymised and cannot be withdrawn, as it will no longer be possible to identify your individual responses. For more information, please refer to [Wbs participant information leaflet 2025-26](#)

Picture this: a company builds an AI version of someone after they pass away, trained on their texts, photos, voice notes, videos, the small everyday things that made them who they were. Their family can talk to it, hear it respond in something like their voice, watch it react the way they might have. That's what the next set of questions is about, not anyone you've personally lost, just your honest reaction to the idea itself. You will not be asked about your own experiences of bereavement or loss.

*Please click below if you wish to proceed

☐ I wish to proceed

Next page >



Let's start with a few quick questions about you. This helps us understand who's answering.

*Are you 18 years of age or older?

☐ Yes

☐ No

What is your age?

What is your gender?

☐ Female

☐ Male

☐ Self Describe

☐ Prefer not to say

How familiar are you with AI tools like ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude or other LLMs?

☐ Not at all familiar

☐ Slightly familiar

☐ Moderately familiar

☐ Very familiar

☐ Extremely familiar

Desktop survey preview

- ☐ Moderately familiar
- ☐ Very familiar
- ☐ Extremely familiar

Before this survey, were you aware AI could be used to create digital representations of people after their passing?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

What is your current country of residence?

United Kingdom

▼

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This next set is about accuracy. Setting emotions aside for a moment, how well do you think an AI could actually get the details right? Their personality, how they spoke, the memories they'd want remembered.

Share your thoughts

	Strongly Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
Given enough personal data, I believe this AI could genuinely capture who they really were — not just surface details.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
It would sound like them: their tone, their turns of phrase, even their humour.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
If this AI shared a memory or detail about deceased person's life, I'd believe it actually happened that way.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

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Now the emotional side. Even if an AI got the details right, would you trust it to handle something this sensitive with genuine care and not just perform empathy, but actually act in people's best interest?

What do you think?

	Strongly Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
This AI would treat their memory with care and act in the best interests of the people grieving.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I'd feel okay talking to an AI built from someone who has passed away.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
This AI can be trusted to know when a topic is emotionally sensitive.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

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Something like this would need a lot of personal data to work like messages, photos, videos, voice recordings. This section is about how you feel about that data: who holds it, who can see it, and what control people should have over it.

What is your view?

	Strongly Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
Strong privacy and security safeguards for their data would be essential for me to trust this.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I'd want to know exactly who can see the data used to build this AI.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I should get a say in who can access data tied to someone's digital legacy.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

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This part isn't about the technology itself, but about who's in charge of it — regulation, transparency, and whether the person being recreated should have had a say before it happened.

Share your opinion

	Strongly Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
Clear regulation and independent oversight, from regulators or ethics boards, would increase my trust in this.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Companies should be upfront about how they build and run this.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The person should have agreed to this themselves, while they were still alive.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
This kind of technology should only be offered by licensed professionals, such as therapists, not general consumer apps.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Last set on this topic — pulling everything together. Taking accuracy, care, privacy, and oversight all into account, what's your overall gut reaction to this idea?

Please indicate your level of agreement with each statement.

	Strongly Disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
Overall, I'd trust the idea of an AI legacy like this.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
With the right safeguards, I believe this could be done responsibly.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Given proper safeguards, I'd actually consider using something like this myself.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I'd support other people having the option to use it, even if I wouldn't myself.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐



Almost done. This last question optional and in your own words. Skip it if you'd rather not.

What's your overall reaction to this idea and what's driving it?



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Appendix B: Research Ethics Form

Response Summary:

Supervisor Approval Guidance notes

There is guidance on the research ethics approval process [on the teaching site here](#).

The responses provided by the student are contained within this online form. You must now **scroll down and click through** the online form and provide your response at the end.

Please do not make any changes to the student's answers.

You will be able to provide feedback to the student at the end if you are rejecting the form, or approving with conditions.

2025-2026 Student Application for Research Ethics Approval

This form is applicable to all types of student dissertation or research project. You should consult with your supervisor before completing this form. There is comprehensive guidance on completing this form in your Student Handbook.

You must not start any data collection before Ethical Approval has been granted. Please note: submission of this form does not mean that the research has been granted ethical approval. Your supervisor will review and approve this form.

This form should take you around 30 minutes to complete, depending on the type of research you are planning.

Ethical Approval is delegated to the students' supervisor and can only be given for **low risk research projects**.

You will be guided through the form and asked to confirm a number of statements to ensure that your research is eligible for review as low-risk. We hope that this form helps you think about the ethical dimensions of your research.

You will be notified of the outcome via email when your Research Ethics Form has been reviewed by your supervisor.

Once approved, you must upload confirmation of your Ethics Approval to my.wbs. You must also include a copy of your Research Ethics Approval as part of your final submission.

Research Ethics Online Training Certificate

In order to prepare you for your Research Ethics application, you must have completed your online Research Ethics Training before you submit this form. This is a University requirement, and all staff and students delivering research are required to complete the following modules from the Full Epigeum Training Programme as a minimum:

- 1. Responsible research practice**
- 2. Irresponsible research practice**

There will be elements of this training which you will find helpful to support you with your research, as well as elements aimed at full-time researchers.

You will find the link to the Epigeum online training modules here:

<https://warwick.ac.uk/services/ris/research-integrity/training/online-training/>

Q4.

Please upload your certificate of completion for Module 1 'Responsible research practice' here before continuing.

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q5. Please upload your certificate of completion for Module 2 'Irresponsible research practice' here before continuing.

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q6. Which type of programme are you enrolled on at WBS?

- Full-time Masters (MSc)

Q7. Which course are you enrolled on at WBS?

- MSc Management (MIM)

Q8. Please select your Programme Team email address below

Please check that this is correct, based on your course selection. We will use this to notify your Programme Team of your Research Ethics submission and outcome.

- ManagementPG@wbs.ac.uk

Q11.

Student details

Please enter your details below very carefully, as we will use this information to notify you of your Research Ethics Form outcome. If you enter incorrect details, you will need to submit this form again. Please make sure you only use your Warwick student ID number without the "u" e.g. 1234567

Student 1 Full name	Sakshi Yugesh Sakle
Student 1 ID Number (without "u")	5667249
Please re-enter your ID number (do not copy paste)	5667249
Student 2 Full name	N/A
Student 2 ID Number (without "u")	N/A
Please re-enter your ID number (do not copy paste)	N/A
Student 3 Full name	N/A
Student 3 ID Number (without "u")	N/A
Please re-enter your ID number (do not copy paste)	N/A

Q12.

Supervisor details

You will find this information on the supervisor allocation email from your Programme Team. Please do not submit this form if you have not been allocated a supervisor yet. Please make sure that you enter this correctly, as we will use this to request your Research Ethics Approval.

What is the name of your allocated supervisor?

Joshua Fullard

Q13. Please enter your supervisor's email address.

You will find this information on the supervisor allocation email from your Programme Team. Please make sure that you double-check and enter this correctly, as we will use this to request your Research Ethics Approval. If you enter this email address incorrectly you may need to submit the form again.

Joshua.Fullard@wbs.ac.uk

Q14. Please re-enter your supervisor's email address (do not copy-paste).

Joshua.Fullard@wbs.ac.uk

Your Research

You will be guided through the next set of questions about your planned research to determine whether your research is eligible for low-risk review, or even REF waiver.

Completing this form should be a useful exercise to support you in planning your research, by prompting you to think carefully about aspects of your research methodology.

Some of the questions presented to you will be determined by your answers to previous questions so please make sure that you check all your answers as you go.

Please provide as much information about your research as possible.

Q16. What is the current title for your research?

The Influence of AI-Based Digital Legacy Systems on User Trust, Emotional Engagement, and Ethical Governance

Q17. What are your research aims?

The aim of this research is to explore user trust in AI-based digital legacy systems and examine whether individuals are willing to trust artificial intelligence with emotionally significant aspects of human identity, memory, and legacy after death.

The specific objectives of the study are:

1. To investigate users' perceptions of the trustworthiness of AI-based digital legacy systems.
2. To examine how perceptions of emotional sensitivity and the preservation of identity influence trust in AI-based digital legacy systems.
3. To explore the impact of privacy concerns on user trust in AI-based digital legacy systems.
4. To assess the role of ethical governance, transparency, and consent in fostering trust in AI-based digital legacy systems.
5. To evaluate whether trust influences users' willingness to engage with and support the use of AI-based digital legacy systems.

Q18. Please tick all of the research methods below that you plan to utilise:

- Primary data collection
- Literature-based research or documentary analysis

Q19. Which type of secondary data will you be using in your research? Please tick all options which are relevant:

- Other - please specify:
Academic literature, peer-reviewed journal articles, books, industry reports, policy documents, and publicly available publications used for the literature review and theoretical framework.

Q21. What sort of primary data collection will you be conducting? Please tick all that apply to your research:

- Questionnaires or surveys

Q23.**Low-risk research**

In order to help you ensure that your research is eligible for low-risk ethical review and approval, you will now be asked to confirm a number of statements. If you are unable to confirm any of these statements, you will need to consult with your supervisor on how to either amend your research, or apply for approval from the University's Humanities and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee (HSSREC).

Please tick to confirm that your research:

- **Does not** investigate sensitive or intrusive matters or topics which participants may find difficult, distressing or cause anxiety, topics which could lead to negative consequences for the participant (e.g. health status, criminal activity, or sexual history).
- **Does not** take place in dangerous locations (e.g., countries where [FCDO travel warnings](#) are in place).
- **Does not** involve the collection of sensitive personal data. Sensitive personal data, also known as special category data, is confidential information that, if disclosed, could cause harm or discrimination to an individual (e.g. racial or ethnic origin, political opinions, religious or philosophical beliefs).
- **Does not** involve payment or financial incentive, or reward, of any sort to participants using the researcher's own money.

Q24. Please read the following statements carefully and tick whether your research will involve any of the following.

A note of clarification regarding conflicts of interest statement: If no ethical implications are anticipated as a result of an existing relationship (e.g. the researcher is engaging with colleagues on a topic related to their professional role), the study can progress under the low-risk remit, but the conflict of interest should be stated.

<i>Participants who are particularly vulnerable or unable to give informed consent or in a dependent position (children, over-researched groups, people with learning difficulties, people with mental health problems, young offenders, people in care facilities, prisoners).</i>	No
<i>People without their consent or knowledge at the time, and / or involve deception of any sort (e.g. covert observation of people in non-public places).</i>	No
<i>Young person(s) under the age of 18 years.</i>	No
<i>Participants who are involved in, or have been involved in, any unlawful activities.</i>	No

Primary research in partnership with, or where the participants are employed by, the UK / armed forces, other military organisations (including contractors) or are employed by any overseas military organisations in any capacity.	No
Risks of possible disclosures or reporting obligations (e.g. research that covers topics where participants may reveal sensitive information such as risk of harm to themselves or others, professional malpractice or insecure migration status that would need to be reported to relevant authorities).	No

<i>Risk of inducing psychological distress or anxiety, or produce humiliation, or cause harm, or lead to negative consequences beyond the risks encountered in normal life</i>	No
<i>Physiological harm, exertion or discomfort for participants.</i>	No
<i>Administration of any substance to participants, or any physically intrusive procedures, the use of bodily materials or human tissue, or DNA/RNA analysis.</i>	No
<i>'Conflicts of interests for the researcher(s) in undertaking the study that pose significant ethical risks. For example, relationships with participating organisations which may be negatively impacted by the proposed study; potentially coercive recruitment (e.g. with the researcher's own employees).</i>	No

<i>Purposefully recruiting pregnant individuals to participate in research. Students must put in place steps to make sure that anyone who may be pregnant is not put under any risk whatsoever during the course of the study.</i>	No
<i>The transfer (physically, electronically or verbally) any data, technologies, material, equipment or know-how, to any non-UK organisation, that could be used to support the design, development, production, stockpiling or use of nuclear, chemical or biological weapons.</i>	No

<i>The use of social media data which has the potential to cause harm / distress or puts at risk the confidentiality and rights of social media users.</i>	No
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Q26. Does your project involve the NHS or social care in any way?

- No

Q30. Does your research involve the Ministry of Defence in any way?

- No

Q32. Research Intervention

An “intervention” here is understood as a systematic controlled change of participant or research conditions, which could be psychological or physical. It can include but is not limited to changes in diet, activity, access to information, or use of certain products.

Students are not permitted to undertake interventions where there is any risk whatsoever to participants.

Examples of permitted interventions may include:

- the trialling of new business models or interventions;
- the testing of engineering solutions which have previously been given ethical approval; providing that such testing adheres to all steps laid down in the original form and that students work closely with supervising academics.
- scientific experiments in the lab or workshops conducted under strict discipline-specific conditions where a full health and safety assessment has been conducted and under close supervision.

If the intervention involves giving an individual or group an advantage over another (for example, interventions which involve the trialling of a new model in education) steps must be taken to assure that no one is disadvantaged.

Does your research involve an intervention?

- No

Data Collection

In this section you should think about how you are going to collect your data, what data you are going to collect, and why you require this data for your research.

You should include a clear description of your study design – a suitable design should reflect the aim(s) of the study. This may include interviews, ethnography/observations, focus groups, questionnaires, document analysis etc.

Q35. Please describe in more detail the data collection methods and tools you will use for your research design.

Please include the answers to the following questions:

- How will you collect your data? e.g. using an online form
- What software or tools will you use in your data collection?
- What data will you collect specifically?
- What sampling techniques will you use?

Reminder: Students are only permitted to use [Qualtrics](#) or [MS Forms](#) for online surveys and questionnaires. These tools have been approved by the University's Information Governance team as secure for hosting data. Survey Monkey is not currently a University-approved service. The University recommends MS Teams for Business as a secure platform for online interviews. This can be accessed via [Office 365](#).

We will need you to include a sufficient level of detail about your data collection methods. Make sure that you are considering the ethical implications of your data collection methods, what are the risks and how can you mitigate these?

Data will be collected through an anonymous online survey administered using Qualtrics, the University of Warwick's approved survey platform. The survey link will be distributed through university networks, LinkedIn, and other relevant online communities. Participation will be voluntary and restricted to individuals aged 18 years and above.

The survey will collect demographic information (e.g., age group, gender, and familiarity with AI technologies) together with participants' perceptions of AI-based digital legacy systems. Specifically, the questionnaire will examine user trust, emotional engagement, privacy concerns, ethical governance, and willingness to engage with such technologies. Responses will primarily be collected through five-point Likert-scale questions, with a small number of optional open-ended questions.

The main ethical consideration is that the survey concerns topics relating to memory, digital legacy, and the use of AI technologies to recreate aspects of a person after death. Although participants will not be asked about their personal experiences of bereavement, grief, trauma, or loss, some individuals may nevertheless find these topics emotionally sensitive. To mitigate this risk, participants will be informed about the nature of the study before participation through the Participant Information Leaflet and consent process. They will be reminded that participation is voluntary, that they may skip any question they do not wish to answer, and that they may withdraw from the survey at any time before submitting their responses.

No personally identifiable information, such as names, email addresses, or contact details, will be collected. Survey responses will remain anonymous and will be stored securely on University-approved systems with access restricted to the researcher and academic supervisor. Findings will be reported only in aggregate form to ensure that individual participants cannot be identified.

A convenience sampling approach will be used, supplemented by snowball sampling whereby participants may share the survey with other eligible individuals. No financial incentives or payments will be offered for participation.

Q36.

Where will the data collection take place?

We care about your safety, and therefore students are not permitted to travel to any dangerous/risky locations (e.g., countries with [FCDO travel warnings](#) in place, dangerous locations within or outside the UK, lone working where the researcher may be at any risk outside of usual activities).

If your research is taking place in a country or specific area with a travel warning in place (e.g. your country of residence), you may need to seek additional approval from HSSREC. Please discuss this with your supervisor and provide as much detail as possible about the nature of the travel, specific location(s) and any mitigation already in place.

Data collection will take place online through Qualtrics. Participants will access the survey remotely through a web link distributed via university networks, LinkedIn, and other online channels. No in-person data collection or travel will be required.

As the study is conducted entirely online, there are no anticipated risks associated with travel, fieldwork, or data collection in dangerous locations. Participants may complete the survey from any location of their choosing, provided they are aged 18 years or above and have experience using AI technologies.

Q37. Please explain clearly how you will recruit your survey/interview participants.

How will you find and contact your participants? Are they people that you already know? Will you be advertising for participation? If so, how?

Participants will be recruited through online channels, including university networks, LinkedIn, and other relevant online communities where individuals with experience using AI technologies may be present. The survey link will be distributed through posts, messages, and email invitations where appropriate.

A convenience sampling approach will be used, whereby participants who meet the eligibility criteria (aged 18 years or above and having experience with AI technologies) may voluntarily choose to participate. Snowball sampling may also be used by inviting participants to share the survey link with other eligible individuals within their personal or professional networks.

Some participants may be known to the researcher through academic, professional, or social networks. However, participation will be entirely voluntary, and no individual will be under any obligation to take part. No incentives or payments will be offered for participation.

All recruitment materials will provide clear information about the purpose of the study and include a link to the Participant Information Sheet and consent process before participants begin the survey.

Q39. How many interview or survey participants are you going to recruit?

The target sample size is approximately 150–200 participants. A minimum of 100 completed responses will be sought to ensure sufficient data for statistical analysis. Participants will be adults aged 18 years or above with experience using AI technologies.

Q41.

Participant documents

It is very important that you explain, in advance, to prospective participants what happens to their data in terms of confidentiality and / or anonymity. You should also explain, in advance, how an individual may withdraw from the study and at what point withdrawal becomes no longer viable.

If you are conducting any surveys, interviews or focus groups you must upload a copy of your Participant Information Leaflet (PIL) and Participant Consent form, which you must complete and provide to all participants.

If you are conducting a combination of surveys, interviews and focus groups, you may need to amend your PIL for each participant type.

You can find templates for your participant documents in your Student Handbook.

Please upload your completed Participant Information Leaflet

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q42. Please upload your completed Participant Consent Form

[\[Click here\]](#)

Q43. Does your research involve the collection, analysis, or storage of personally identifiable data?

Personally identifiable data is any direct or indirect information about an individual that may make it possible to identify them (physical, genetic, demographic, cultural, political, professional identity, etc.).

- No

Q45. Does your research involve the collection, analysis, or storage of participants' protected characteristics?

This refers to the protected characteristics as defined by the Equality Act [2020]. A person's protected characteristics include: age, disability, gender reassignment, marriage and civil partnership, pregnancy and maternity, race, religion or belief, sex, sexual orientation. Please note that the collection and reporting of basic demographic data such as participant's age and sex is standard scientific practice and you will be expected to give a demographic breakdown of the sample you have collected for your research.

You can find out more about protected characteristics here:

<https://www.equalityhumanrights.com/en/equality-act/protected-characteristics>

- Yes

Q46. Please detail which protected characteristics you will be including, and why you need this information. Please explain how and why this contributes to your research.

The study will collect participants' age group and sex/gender to provide a demographic profile of the sample and to explore whether perceptions of AI-based digital legacy systems differ across demographic groups. This information will help contextualise and interpret the survey findings. All demographic data will be collected anonymously and analysed in aggregate form only.

Q49.

Data security

Students must comply with the regulations and policies about data collection, transfer, processing and storage: https://warwick.ac.uk/services/ris/research-integrity/research_code_of_practice/datacollection_retention/research_data_mgt_policy/

Data must be stored securely and students are encouraged not to store any data on external devices (including mobile phones, voice recording equipment, external hard drives, USB sticks, etc). We recommend where possible that students store their data on Warwick servers (e.g. OneDrive). Students are not permitted to share data with any other individual outside of the immediate research team.

How will you ensure the security of the data you collect?

Please explain:

- **How you will address the issue of anonymity?**
- **How and by whom will any data be transcribed, coded, de-identified, stored, transferred, accessed, archived?**
- **How and where will you store your data?**

The study will collect anonymous survey responses through Qualtrics, the University of Warwick's approved survey platform. No personally identifiable information, such as names, email addresses, or contact details, will be collected. Participants will therefore remain anonymous throughout the study. Survey data will be downloaded and stored securely on University-approved systems, such as Warwick OneDrive, with access restricted to the researcher and academic supervisor. Data will be used solely for the purposes of this research project and will not be shared outside the research team. As the survey is anonymous, no transcription or de-identification procedures will be required. Responses will be coded and analysed by the researcher using statistical software. Research findings will be reported in aggregate form only to ensure that individual participants cannot be identified. Data will be retained and managed in accordance with the University of Warwick's Research Data Management Policy and applicable data protection requirements.

Q50.

Data Analysis

Please specify the data analysis method(s) for your research design.

Please explain:

- Which analysis methods you will use for your research? E.g. content analysis, framework analysis, interpretative phenomenological analysis etc. and any statistical analyses.
- Will you be using any software for the analysis, and how will it be used?

The study will use quantitative data analysis methods to analyse survey responses. Descriptive statistics, including frequencies, percentages, means, and standard deviations, will be used to summarise participant demographics and survey responses. Where appropriate, inferential statistical analyses, such as correlation analysis and regression analysis, may be conducted to examine relationships between key variables, including user trust, emotional engagement, ethical governance, and willingness to adopt AI-based digital legacy systems. Survey data will be exported from Qualtrics and analysed using appropriate statistical software, such as Jamovi, SPSS, or Microsoft Excel. The software will be used to organise the data, generate descriptive statistics, and conduct any relevant statistical analyses required to address the research objectives.

Q51.

Student declaration for Ethical Approval.

In order to ensure that you have accessed the relevant information and guidance on research integrity, and that the information you have provided is accurate, please tick to confirm that you agree with the statements below:

- The information in this form together with any accompanying information is complete and correct to the best of my knowledge and belief, and I take full responsibility for it.
- I have accessed the necessary training about research ethics and have consulted my supervisor to confirm that the data sources I intend to access are acceptable.
- I undertake to abide by the University of Warwick's [Research Code of Practice](#) and other relevant professional and University policies, regulations, procedures and guidelines in undertaking this research.
- I confirm I am familiar with and will conduct my research in line with the [University's Data Protection Policy including](#) General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and Data Protection Act 2018 (DPA 2018). I will report any data breaches to the University's Information and Data Director: dpo@warwick.ac.uk
- I understand that I must not begin any research until I have received ethical approval from the supervisor to proceed.
- I understand that any changes that I would like to make to this study after receiving approval from WBS, require further review. As such they must be submitted via a new Research Ethics Form before such changes are implemented.

Click NEXT to submit your Research Ethics Form. You will not be able to return and edit your responses once you move past this page.

Your responses will be automatically sent to your supervisor for review.

Supervisor outcome

Q55.

Please select which outcome you are providing for this Research Ethics Approval form.

All supervisors must grant or waive ethical approval for their student's research project BEFORE the student carries out data collection.

- Research Ethics [Approval granted with conditions](#)

Q56. You have selected, "Ethical approval granted with conditions". This means that you are granting approval if the student makes some minor revisions to the REF, or implements some additional mitigation to risks identified.

The student will not have to resubmit a new REF for review. If the REF needs major revisions, you should reject and the student will need to resubmit.

By uploading their confirmation of Research Ethics Approval with conditions to my.wbs, the student is accepting responsibility for the implementation of the stated conditions, with support from their supervisor.

Please detail below the revisions or amendments that are required as a condition of your research ethics approval.

Writing what we just spoke about: As long as you do not ask about personal experiences everything is hypothetical and focused on technology and the different applications of technology.

Q59.

Document check

Please confirm that you have seen and checked that the following documents have been submitted with this Research Ethics Form. You will find the links to check these documents in the email sent to you requesting your approval (titled "ACTION REQUIRED: New Research Ethics Form for your Approval").

Research Integrity Epigeum Training Certificates (all students) - Module 1 & 2	Checked
Participant Information Leaflet	Checked
Participant Consent Form	Checked

Q60.

Supervisor Signature

Please sign to confirm that you believe that the student (or SCP group) has fully considered the ethical dimensions of their proposed research, and that the project is eligible for [student delegated low-risk ethical approval](#), which you are granting.

Joshua f

Embedded Data:

Q_URL	https://wbs.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_3m8kAWiPZhRkjwW?Q_R=R_2K7iVAm4gcFEq4A&Q_R_DEL=1
Student 1 email	u5667249@live.warwick.ac.uk
Student 2 email	u@live.warwick.ac.uk
Student 3 email	u@live.warwick.ac.uk

Appendix C: Participant Information Leaflet



Participant Information Leaflet

Study Title: The Influence of AI-Based Digital Legacy Systems on User Trust, Emotional Engagement, and Ethical Governance

Investigator(s): Sakshi Yugesh Sakle
sakshi-yugesh.sakle@warwick.ac.uk

Introduction

You are invited to take part in a research study. Before you decide, you need to understand why the research is being done and what it would involve for you. Please take the time to read the following information carefully. Talk to others about the study if you wish.

Please ask us if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information. Take time to decide whether or not you wish to take part.

Who is organising and funding the study?

This study is being conducted by Sakshi Yugesh Sakle as part of an MSc Management dissertation at Warwick Business School, University of Warwick. The research is being undertaken to fulfil the requirements of the MSc Management programme and is not funded by any external organisation.

What is the study about?

This study explores how users of AI technologies perceive AI-based digital legacy systems. These systems use artificial intelligence to preserve, recreate, or simulate aspects of an individual's digital presence after their death.

The research aims to understand how people evaluate these technologies in terms of trust, emotional engagement, privacy, and ethical governance. As AI technologies continue to develop, understanding public attitudes towards these systems is important for informing responsible innovation, policy development, and ethical practices.

As part of the survey, participants will be asked to consider topics relating to death, digital legacy, memory, and the use of AI technologies to recreate aspects of deceased individuals. The study focuses on perceptions of these technologies and does not require participants to discuss their own experiences of bereavement or personal loss.

What would taking part involve?

If you decide to take part, you will be asked to complete an online questionnaire.

The questionnaire will include questions about:

- Your experience with and use of AI technologies;

- Your perceptions of AI-based digital legacy systems;
- Trust in AI-generated representations;
- Potential emotional value and concerns associated with these systems;
- Privacy, security, and ethical considerations relating to AI and digital legacy technologies.

The questionnaire is expected to take approximately **10–15 minutes** to complete.

Participation involves completing a single online survey. There will be no follow-up activities, interviews, or focus groups.

No audio or video recording will take place.

Do I have to take part?

No. Participation in this study is completely voluntary and choosing not to take part will not affect you in any way. You can also choose to withdraw your participation without giving a reason by contacting one of the research team. Further details about withdrawing from the study are provided later on in this document.

What are the possible benefits of taking part in this study?

While there may be no direct personal benefit from participating, your responses will contribute to a better understanding of how people perceive emerging AI technologies in the context of digital legacy management.

The findings may help researchers, policymakers, and technology developers better understand public expectations regarding trust, emotional engagement, privacy, and ethical governance in AI-based digital legacy systems.

What are the possible disadvantages, side effects or risks, of taking part in this study?

This study is considered low risk. However, the survey includes questions relating to death, digital legacy, memory, and the use of artificial intelligence to preserve, recreate, or simulate aspects of deceased individuals. Some participants may find these topics emotionally sensitive or uncomfortable. Participants will not be asked to discuss their own experiences of bereavement, personal loss, or other sensitive personal experiences.

You may skip any question you do not wish to answer and may withdraw from the survey at any point before submitting your responses.

If you experience discomfort while participating, you are encouraged to discontinue the survey.

Expenses and payments

There are no costs associated with participating in this study.

Participants will not receive any payment, reimbursement, or incentive for taking part.

Will my taking part be kept confidential?

Yes.

Data will be collected through an online survey platform and used solely for the purposes of this research project.

No personally identifiable information such as names, addresses, telephone numbers, or email addresses will be collected.

Survey responses will be stored securely on password-protected University-approved systems. Access to the data will be restricted to the researcher and academic supervisor.

The results will be reported in aggregate form only, and no participant will be identifiable in any dissertation, publication, or presentation arising from this research.

What will happen to the data collected about me?

As a publicly funded organisation, the University of Warwick has to ensure that it is in the public interest when we use personally identifiable information from people who have agreed to take part in research. This means that when you agree to take part in a research study, such as this, we will use your data in the ways needed to conduct and analyse the research study.

We will be using information from you to undertake this study and will act as the data controller for this study. We are committed to protecting the rights of individuals in line with data protection legislation.

No identifiable personal data will be collected as part of this study.

Once survey responses have been submitted, it will not be possible to identify individual responses. Consequently, it will not be possible to withdraw submitted data after survey completion.

Research data will be stored securely in accordance with University of Warwick data management and data protection policies and retained for the period required by university regulations.

The University of Warwick will act as the data controller for this research.

Data Sharing

No research data will be shared with organisations outside the University of Warwick. Access to the data will be restricted to the researcher and academic supervisor for the purposes of this dissertation project.

This data will be used solely for the completion of the MSc Management dissertation and any associated academic assessment requirements. The data will not be used for future research beyond the scope of this project.

Your rights to access, change or move your information are limited, as we need to manage your information in specific ways in order for the research to be reliable and accurate. The University of Warwick has in place policies and procedures to keep your data safe.

For further information, please refer to the University of Warwick Research Privacy Notice

which is available here:

<https://warwick.ac.uk/services/idc/dataprotection/privacynotices/researchprivacynotice> or by contacting the Legal and Compliance Team at info@compliance@warwick.ac.uk.

What will happen if I don't want to carry on being part of the study?

Participation is entirely voluntary.

You may exit the survey at any point before submission without providing a reason.

Because no personally identifiable information will be collected, it will not be possible to identify and remove individual responses after submission.

To safeguard your rights, we will use the minimum personally-identifiable information possible and keep the data secure in line with the University's Information and Data Compliance policies.

What will happen to the results of the study?

The findings from this study will form part of an MSc Management dissertation submitted to Warwick Business School.

The results may also be presented at academic conferences or included in future academic publications. Any reporting of findings will use anonymised and aggregated data, ensuring that participants cannot be identified.

Who has reviewed the study?

This study has been reviewed and given favourable opinion by WBS, which reports to the University of Warwick's Humanities and Social Science Research Ethics Committee (HSSREC).

Who should I contact if I want further information?

Sakshi Yugesh Sakle
Email: sakshi-yugesh.sakle@warwick.ac.uk
MSc Management Student
Warwick Business School, University of Warwick

Supervisor: Joshua Fullard
Email: Joshua.Fullard@wbs.ac.uk
Warwick Business School, University of Warwick

Who should I contact if I wish to make a complaint?

Any complaint about the way you have been dealt with during the study or any possible harm you might have suffered will be addressed. Please address your complaint to the person below, who is a senior University of Warwick official entirely independent of this study:

Head of Research Governance

Research & Impact Services
University House
University of Warwick
Coventry
CV4 8UW
Email: researchgovernance@warwick.ac.uk
Tel: 02476 575733

If you wish to raise a complaint on how we have handled your personal data, you can contact our Data Protection Officer who will investigate the matter: DPO@warwick.ac.uk.

If you are not satisfied with our response or believe we are processing your personal data in a way that is not lawful you can complain to the Information Commissioner's Office (ICO).

Thank you for taking the time to read this Participant Information Leaflet

Appendix D: Participant Consent Form

**UNIVERSITY
OF WARWICK**



CONSENT FORM

Participant Identification Number for this study:

Title of Project: The Influence of AI-Based Digital Legacy Systems on User Trust, Emotional Engagement, and Ethical Governance

Name of Researcher(s): Sakshi Yugesh Sakle and Joshua Fullard

1. I confirm that I have read and understand the information sheet for the above study. I have had the opportunity to consider the information, ask questions and have had these answered satisfactorily.
2. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw my participation at any time without giving any reason, without my legal rights being affected.
3. I understand that I can request to withdraw my data until survey submission.
4. I understand that in very rare events the collected data might be consulted by relevant regulatory bodies, such as the Head of Research Governance or appropriate authorities. Anonymity will be maintained wherever possible.
5. I am happy for my anonymised data to be used in future research.
6. I agree to take part in the above study.

☐
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☐
☐
☐

Name of Participant

Date

Signature

Sakshi Yugesh Sakle

09/06/2026

SAKSHI YUGESH SAKLE

Name of Person
taking consent

Date

Signature